received the best care available at the time, yet they died at a far higher rate than in other countries. No suitable explanation has yet been found but one factor may have been the constant journeying these young mothers were subject to, in swaying howdahs and lurching camels.

The country was at the time in the grip of a terrible famine, which lasted for more than three years. It brought epidemics, which ‘depopulated whole houses and cities, to say nothing of hamlets and villages’. Grain was so scarce ‘that men ate their own kind, and the streets and roads were blocked with dead bodies’. Desperate parents were allowed to sell their children, a long-standing practice in times of famine; Badauni wrote that they could buy back their children if they were able to repay their price. In Srinagar, Akbar ordered food kitchens to be set up in twelve places. He also began the building of a stone fortress at Hari Parbat, a hill overlooking Srinagar, for which a large number of labourers were employed; through their pay, it was hoped that some of the effects of the famine would be alleviated. It was around this time, as pointed out by Irfan Habib, that Akbar began to have reservations about the practice of forced labour. He abolished fifty-five ‘un-praiseworthy practices’ such as being forced to clean the saffron flowers during harvest season. An inscription was put up in 1598, at the wall of the fort he built, clarifying that the Padshah ‘sent one crore and ten lakh from the Treasury, and 200 Indian masters as workmen. No one did work by way of be-gar (forced labour) here. All received money from his treasury.’

Akbar wanted to remain in Kashmir through the winter of 1597 but by September the cold was so intense that ‘the inhabitants of hot countries became somewhat inconvenienced’ and so the Mughal party set off by boat, first to survey the saffron fields being harvested. The Jesuit party had gone ahead of the Mughals, and arrived in Lahore on 13 November, where ‘the people of the town exhibited towards the Father and his companion a more friendly attitude than was their wont. It had previously been their practice,’ wrote the resigned Jesuits, ‘to throw stones at them and offer them other insults.’

In December of this year the Jesuits celebrated Christmas in their new church at Lahore with much fanfare, to the entertainment of the locals. They presented a play around the birth of Christ liberally interspersed with ‘Indian’ language phrases and this ‘was greatly appreciated by the people of the country’. The people of Lahore enthusiastically joined in the celebrations, praying to the baby Jesus ‘as though He were actually lying in